

Opening and Response

1NT and 2NT describe the hand almost completely: responder adds up the points and picks the contract.

1 The 1NT opening

15, 16 or 17 HCP and a balanced hand (4-3-3-3, 4-4-3-2, 5-3-3-2): open 1NT, which takes priority over a suit opening.

It promises at least two cards in every suit.

♠ KQ76 ♥ AQ62 ♦ KQ7 ♣ 98 16 HCP, 4-4-3-2

1NT

♠ J6 ♥ KQ7 ♦ KJ2 ♣ AJ854 15 HCP, 5-3-3-2

1NT

2 Responder is the captain

Responder knows opener holds 15-17, adds their own points and chooses the level. Responses are sign-offs, invitations or forcing bids.

Sign-offs · opener passes

2♥ 2♠ weak hand (0-7) with 5+ cards: part score

3NT game values, no fit

4♥ 4♠ a sure fit and game values

Invitations · opener decides

2NT with 8 HCP: opener passes with 15, bids 3NT with 16-17

3♥ 3♠ "raise with a maximum, otherwise pass"

over 1NT ♠ AQ8743 ♥ K5 ♦ J42 ♣ 76 10 HCP, 6 spades: fit and game

4♠

over 1NT ♠ 876 ♥ J109652 ♦ 42 ♣ 76 1 HCP, 6 hearts: 2♥ beats 1NT

2♥

3 Stayman: 2♣

With **at least 8 HCP** and a four- or five-card major, responder asks: "do you have four hearts or four spades?"

2♦

neither 4 hearts nor 4 spades

2♥

4 hearts, fewer than 4 spades

2♠

4 spades, fewer than 4 hearts

2NT

4 hearts and 4 spades

♠ KJ76 ♥ A842 ♦ 65 ♣ K83

1NT - 2♣ - 2♥ - 4♥

4-4 fit found, game values.

opener ♠ AK86 ♥ Q93 ♦ KJ7 ♣ A84

Over 2♣ opener bids 2♠: four spades and fewer than four hearts.

4-4 fit found: game, or slam.

No fit: play in notrump, at the level the points allow.

A 5-3 fit still possible: responder bids the five-card suit.

4 The 2NT opening

21, 22 or 23 HCP and a balanced hand: no singletons, no voids, no six-card suits.

Pass part-score hand

3♥ 3♠ 5+ card suit, game values: opener raises with a fit, otherwise bids 3NT

3♣ Stayman: 3♦ no four-card major, 3♥ four hearts, 3♠ four spades, 3NT both

3NT game with no four-card major: to play

♠ 95 ♥ J965 ♦ 865 ♣ AJ92

2NT - 3♣ - 3♥ - 4♥

over 2NT ♠ 43 ♥ K52 ♦ AJ952 ♣ 976

3NT

8 HCP, no four-card major: the side holds 29-31, so play 3NT. This direct 3NT denies a four-card major; opener's 3NT after 3♣ shows both.